work again—at least enough to divide their votes into innocuous fragments.

Shah's statement that the BJP's doors are open for young Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) leader Jayant Chaudhary, grandson of Jat icon and former prime minister Charan Singh, is part of the attempt to soften up the irate community. A BJP functionary tells INDIA TODAY, "After the death of Chaudhary Sahab (Ajit Singh), there's a soft corner for Jayant among Jats. They want to see Jayant as their political voice, so rather than targeting Jayant, we are targeting the Samajwadi alliance. We still hope that over half of all Jats will vote BJP."

Jayant is not biting—he's standing firm with the BJP's main rival, the Samajwadi Party (SP). The SP-RLD's main thrust is on aggregating their individual catchment areas, creating a united Jat-Muslim-Yadav votebank that at least theoretically results from their alliance. At the same time, they are mindful of the danger of erosion in their ranks and want to forage further out. That's why the alphabet soup that was the staple of election-watchers in the previous century is back in fashion—with a new permutation. Instead of the old 'AJGAR' umbrella, the talk this time is about the 'GAJAB' formula. To unpack that, one needs to go back to the days when the Congress, in its heyday, held a monopoly over power by bringing together Brahmins, Dalits and Muslims. To counter that, in the 1960s, Charan Singh had prepared a coalition of non-Brahmin, non-Dalit communities with a significant presence in western UP. The AJGAR formula—referring to the alliance he created of Ahirs, Jats, Gujjars and Rajputs—took him to chief ministership and beyond, and opened up the space for non-Congress politics in India.

AJGAR won't quite work now. Ahirs, a synonym for Yadavs, are a dependable bloc for SP chief Akhilesh Yadav but the Rajputs are seen to be completely loyal to the BJP. So they have spun a new power acronym—'GAJAB'. That's an amalgam of Gujjars, Ahirs, Jats and, hold your breath, Brahmins. The SP essentially wants to compensate for the absence of Rajputs with Brahmin votes. However counter-intuitive it may seem for Mandal messiah Mulayam Singh Yadav's son to be pursuing the twice-born, it can make sense in the context of UP—where a section of Brahmins are always said to be upset at being sidelined in Yogi Adityanath's 'Thakur raj'. Hence, the unlikely spectacle of SP leaders bemoaning the neglect of Brahmins. Accomplishing 'GAJAB' may still be a long shot, though. The 'G', Gujjars, are not exactly an automatic shoo-in into a package that includes the Jats—not to speak of the residual Jat-Muslim animus.

Mathura, which also formed part of Shah's itinerary, is another laboratory for that experiment. Here, the BJP is keeping the Krishna Janmabhoomi issue on slow burn, ready in case of emergency. Ram Das, a local *sadhu*, discounts the hype, saying, "Mathura is a town of love and peace. Hatred has no space here." For the SP-RLD alliance, the main headache is to keep the hatred between their workers at a minimum for a successful vote transfer to each other's candidates. The differences that cropped on several seat allocations—for instance, the way RLD's Yogesh Nauwahr had to make way for SP's Haryana import Sanjay Lathar in Mant, a Jat-dominated constituency—amplifies the ground-level discomfort. In Meerut's Siwalkhas, the Jats created a ruckus after the SP got its Muslim candidate to contest on the RLD symbol—putting paid to senior RLD leader Raj Kumar Sangwan's chances. Despite Jayant's firman for unity, and despite all the '*samanvay samiti*s (coordination committees)' on the ground, an old pattern threatens to resurface: Muslims supporting Jat candidates, but Jats not being too keen to return the favour, particularly in seats where the BJP has also fielded a Jat candidate. It's that inner battle of loyalties. ■

## IN THE RUNNING



**SHRIKANT SHARMA**
Uttar Pradesh's power minister, contesting from Mathura

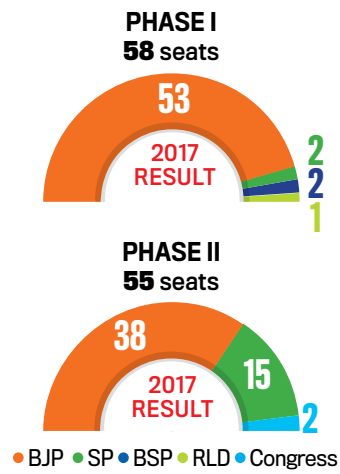
**PANKAJ SINGH**
The son of Union Minister Rajnath Singh, contesting from Noida

**BABY RANI MAURYA**
Projected as a Dalit BJP leader, contesting from Agra (rural)

**AZAM KHAN**
A senior Samajwadi Party leader, Khan, who is currently in jail, is contesting the Rampur Sadar seat. His son Abdullah is contesting from Suar, in the same district

**JAYANT CHAUDHARY**
A Jat icon, Chaudhary's performance in this election will decide his political future

## LAST TIME AROUND




*Graphic by* ASIT ROY